

"JOB SWITCHING"

Adapted from the I Love Lucy episode
Season 2, Episode 1
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Adaptation for Modern Single-Camera Production

FULL EPISODE — FINAL DRAFT

COLD OPEN

FADE IN:

INT. RICARDO APARTMENT - LIVING ROOM - EVENING

A fourth-floor walk-up on East 68th Street, 1952. Faded floral wallpaper. A sofa with cushions pressed into permanent shapes by the same two people every night. Lamps on, overhead off. The radiator under the window ticks steadily. Through the glass - fire escapes, lit windows across the alley, the faint rumble of the Third Avenue El.

Framed photos crowd every surface: the Ricardos' wedding day, Ricky's orchestra at the Tropicana, a snapshot of the two couples at Coney Island. A telephone on the side table sits beside a notepad covered in Lucy's handwriting - phone numbers, doodles, half a grocery list.

LUCY RICARDO, early thirties, sits on the sofa in a fitted periwinkle blouse and charcoal pencil skirt, her red hair pinned in careful curls. Even at home, even at this hour, she is fully put together. She is turning the pages of a magazine she is not reading, her eyes drifting to the front door every few seconds.

The front door opens. RICKY RICARDO enters - mid-thirties, dark-haired, Cuban, still wearing the double-breasted navy suit from his set at the Tropicana, his tie loosened one notch at the collar. He hangs his coat on the brass hook, drops his hat on the entryway table where it always goes.

RICKY

Lucy? Is that you, sweetie pie?

He crosses to her, arms wide.

RICKY (CONT'D)

Oh, gee, I'm glad you're home.
How's about a great big -

LUCY

(already on her feet)
Well, see you later.

She heads for the kitchen. Not running - walking with purpose. Ricky catches her arm.

RICKY

Lucy. Come here.

She stops. Turns. She knows that tone.

LUCY
What's the matter?

RICKY
I stopped by the bank on the way
home and they showed me this.

He pulls a check from his jacket pocket. Holds it up between
two fingers.

LUCY
What's that?

RICKY
Your check to the beauty parlor.

LUCY
I write a check to the beauty
parlor every month.

RICKY
Yes, I know that. But they don't
always have a little note on the
back like this one.

He turns the check over. Lucy's round, looping handwriting
across the back: "Dear teller, be a lamb and don't put this
through till next month."

RICKY (CONT'D)
(reading)
"Dear teller, be a lamb and don't
put this through till next month."
Now what do you have to say for
yourself?

LUCY
(not missing a beat)
That's why they call them tellers –
they go around blabbing everything
they know.

Ricky does not laugh. He tucks the check into his pocket and
faces her.

RICKY
Lucy. Now look. I'm serious. I
don't know what's the matter with
you. Every month – every single
month – your bank account is
overdrawn. Now what is the reason?

LUCY
You don't give me enough money.

RICKY
I don't give you enough money?!

LUCY
Well, we both agree. That must be
the reason.

Ricky's mouth opens. Nothing comes out.

RICKY
Now look, Lucy -

LUCY
(hands folded)
Yes, sir?

RICKY
Do you think this is a game we're
playing?

LUCY
No, sir.

RICKY
Do you realize how tough it is for
a guy to make a buck these days?

LUCY
Yes, sir. Yes, sir.

RICKY
Do you think that money grows on
trees?

LUCY
No.

Lucy picks up her magazine. Conversation over.

A KNOCK at the front door - two heavy raps, a landlord's
knock. Ricky's face brightens. An exit.

RICKY
(to Lucy, already moving)
Well - we'll see you later.

He opens the door. FRED MERTZ, early sixties, stands in the
hallway in a baggy cardigan over a wrinkled white shirt, his
thinning hair combed flat across his scalp. Behind him, ETHEL
MERTZ, his wife - a sturdy woman in a floral print housedress
and a sensible cloth coat, clutching her handbag with both
hands.

RICKY (CONT'D)
(grabbing his hat)
Come on, Fred.

LUCY
(from the sofa)
No, no. Come on. Come in and sit
down.

FRED
No, thanks. I went to the fights
last night.

LUCY
Fred, please come in, will you?
Come in, Ethel.

ETHEL
Yeah, please. Please come in.

The Mertzes enter. The door clicks shut behind them. Lucy and Ethel settle into their respective ends of the sofa. Ethel slips off her coat, sets her bag on the floor. Fred lowers himself into the armchair with a grunt and immediately looks like he's been sitting there for hours. Ricky, escape thwarted, puts his hat back down.

RICKY
I - I - Fred, I want to ask your
advice on a certain subject.

FRED
What subject?

RICKY
Well, tell me something, will you?
How often is Ethel's checking
account overdrawn?

FRED
Never.

RICKY
(stunned)
Never?! How do you manage that?

Fred leans back, fingers laced across his stomach. Ethel waits.

ETHEL
It's easy. I never had enough money
at one time to open a checking
account.

Fred's fingers unlace.

FRED
(sputtering)
What?! She spends money like I was
printing it in the basement.

ETHEL
Printing in the basement. Ha!

FRED
Let's face it, Rick. When it comes
to money, there are two kinds of
people - the earners and the
spenders. Or as they are more
popularly known, husbands and
wives.

RICKY
Yeah.

FRED
Brother, if they had to make the
dollar, they would think twice
before spending it that fast.

RICKY
Yeah.

Lucy sets her magazine down. Ethel stops fussing with her
coat.

LUCY
What's so tough about earning a
living?

ETHEL
Yeah.

FRED
Have you ever done it?

A pause.

LUCY
No. But I could.

FRED
(short laugh)
Ha!

ETHEL
I could too.

FRED
(bigger laugh)
Ha!

RICKY
Listen – holding down a job is a
lot more difficult than lying
around the house all day long.

Lucy's chin drops. That one landed.

LUCY
Lying around the – lying around the
– is that all you think we do?

RICKY
Yeah.

FRED
Well now, let's be fair, Rick.
Every once in a while, they get up
and play canasta.

Ethel's eyes narrow. Lucy's hands go to her hips. She's done
defending.

LUCY
Who do you think does the
housework? And who do you think
cooks all the meals?

ETHEL
Yeah!

He is pacing now.

RICKY
Oh, anybody can cook and do the
housework.

Lucy sees her opening.

LUCY
Ha! I'd just like to see you two
try it for a week.

A beat.

RICKY
Okay. We will.

FRED
(head snapping toward
Ricky)
We will?

RICKY
Yeah.

Fred's face cycles through alarm, protest, and surrender.

LUCY
This I've got to see.

ETHEL
I want to get a load of —

RICKY
(cutting in)
Yeah, but wait a minute. You will
have to go out and earn the living.

LUCY
Okay. We will.

ETHEL
(head snapping toward
Lucy)
We will?

LUCY
Yeah.

The mirror image. Same alarm on Ethel's face that was on
Fred's ten seconds ago. Two marriages. One pattern.

ETHEL
(squaring her shoulders)
We'll change places. We'll get
jobs, and you take care of the
house for a week.

LUCY
Okay?

RICKY
Okay.

LUCY
Okay?

FRED
Okay.

LUCY

Okay.

Four people in a living room. Two couples. One bet none of them can win. Lucy's hands are on her hips. Ricky's chin is lifted. Fred has sunk deeper into the armchair like it's already over. Ethel is gripping her handbag strap with both hands.

Everybody is smiling. Nobody should be.

SMASH CUT TO:

EXT. RICARDO APARTMENT BUILDING - NIGHT

TITLE CARD: "JOB SWITCHING"

The brownstone facade. Fire escapes zigzagging down the front. The Ricardos' windows on the fourth floor, warm and amber. A taxi rolls through the intersection at the end of the block, taillights smearing red on wet pavement.

We hold on the building for a breath.

FADE TO BLACK.

END OF COLD OPEN

ACT ONE

INT. RICARDO APARTMENT - KITCHEN - MORNING

Morning light through the window over the sink. A small kitchen - white tile counters, a four-burner gas stove, a Frigidaire humming in the corner, the checked tablecloth set for two, a percolator steaming on the counter.

RICKY stands at the stove in Lucy's apron - a ruffled, floral thing tied over his undershirt and slacks, the strings knotted awkwardly at his back. He is whistling. On the table: eggs, fried potatoes, toast, orange juice, coffee. It looks perfect.

RICKY

(calling out)

Lucy! Breakfast is ready.

LUCY

(from the other room)

Coming, dear.

LUCY enters in a belted olive day dress and low heels, a string of pearls at her throat – dressed to make an impression at whatever employment office will have her. She stops in the doorway. Takes in the spread.

LUCY (CONT'D)

Well, doesn't this look wonderful.
Did you have any trouble?

RICKY

No. Not a bit.

LUCY

Well – happy housework.

RICKY

Happy job hunting.

LUCY

Thank you.

She sits. Unfolds her napkin. Takes a bite of the eggs. Then the potatoes. Then a sip of coffee.

LUCY (CONT'D)

Oh, boy, does this look good. Mmm.
I'm hungry this morning too.

Another bite. She chews. Nods.

LUCY (CONT'D)

Mmm. It is good.

RICKY

(leaning against the
counter, arms crossed)
Why, naturally. There's nothing to
cooking.

LUCY

Mmm. Oh, the coffee's good too.
Where did you learn to do all this?

RICKY

Oh, I'm just a natural-born cook, I
guess.

Lucy eats. Ricky watches her eat.

RICKY (CONT'D)

Honey, what kind of a job are you
going to get? Are you going to go
to an employment office?

Lucy eats. Does not look up.

RICKY (CONT'D)
Lucy, why don't you answer me?

LUCY
(mouth full, not looking
up)
That's nice, dear.

Ricky stares at her.

LUCY (CONT'D)
(swallowing, looking up)
Okay, I get your message. Now you
know what I go through every
morning.

RICKY
All right. I'll reform.

LUCY
Oh. Gee, these fried potatoes are
just great.

RICKY
I don't see why you're so
surprised. There's nothing to it.

The TELEPHONE rings in the living room. Ricky unties the
apron and goes to answer it. Lucy keeps eating.

INT. RICARDO APARTMENT - LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Ricky picks up the receiver. Through the kitchen doorway,
Lucy is still working on the potatoes.

RICKY
Hello? Yes? Oh, yes. Oh. Well,
thank you very much. Yes. Good-bye.

He hangs up. Stands there a moment. Does not move back toward
the kitchen.

LUCY
(calling from the kitchen)
Who was that? Gee, this is a
sensational breakfast. My gosh, but
you're a good cook.

Ricky walks back to the kitchen doorway. Slowly.

INT. RICARDO APARTMENT - KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

Lucy is buttering toast. She looks up.

LUCY
Who was that on the phone?

RICKY
It was the drugstore.

Lucy stops buttering.

LUCY
The drugstore?

RICKY
I left my hat.

LUCY
When you picked up these two
breakfast orders.

Not a question. She has put it together. Ricky does not deny it.

LUCY (CONT'D)
You know, you could have tried to
cook this yourself. We have a dozen
eggs in the refrigerator.

RICKY
Well, um - they didn't turn out
quite right.

LUCY
The whole dozen?!

RICKY
Yeah.

Lucy looks at him. Ricky looks at the beautiful breakfast he did not make.

LUCY
Oh.

A KNOCK at the kitchen door. ETHEL pushes in - wool coat over a navy dress, a small hat pinned at an angle, her good handbag. Dressed for the outside world.

ETHEL
Morning, everybody.

LUCY
Hi, Ethel.

RICKY
Good morning.

ETHEL
Well, Lucy, are you ready to go to
the office? To the employment
office, that is.

LUCY
Yeah. All ready.

Lucy stands, brushes the crumbs from her lap, picks up her
handbag and gloves from the counter.

LUCY (CONT'D)
Okay, dear. Bye-bye.

RICKY
Bye.

ETHEL
Bye, Ricky.

RICKY
Bye. See you for dinner.

Lucy and Ethel head for the front door. From upstairs,
through the ceiling, FRED'S VOICE:

FRED (O.S.)
Ethel! Ethel, you're leaving.

ETHEL
(not stopping)
Yeah? What about it?

FRED (O.S.)
Well, you forgot to kiss me good-
bye.

Ethel does not go back upstairs. Lucy takes her arm and they
walk out. The door closes behind them.

Ricky stands alone in the kitchen. The apron is folded over a
chair. The beautiful breakfast sits on the table, half-eaten,
fully fraudulent.

CUT TO:

EXT. EAST 68TH STREET - MORNING

Lucy and Ethel on the sidewalk, walking east, shoulder to shoulder. Morning sun on the brownstones. A delivery truck rumbles past. Lucy's heels click on the pavement. Neither woman says a word - the confidence is in the walk.

CUT TO:

INT. EMPLOYMENT AGENCY - WAITING AREA - MORNING

A row of wooden chairs along an institutional green wall, fluorescent lights, a frosted glass window with gold lettering reading EMPLOYMENT SERVICES. The room smells like floor wax and other people's cigarettes.

Lucy and Ethel sit side by side, handbags in their laps - Lucy sitting up straight, performing readiness, Ethel gripping the clasp of her bag.

ETHEL
(leaning in)
Lucy, I'm nervous.

LUCY
So am I.

ETHEL
Do you think this man can really
get jobs for us?

LUCY
Sure he can.

ETHEL
But we don't know how to do
anything.

LUCY
Shh!

Across the room, a MAN rises from a desk, shakes hands with a young woman in a typist's blouse, and hands her a slip of paper.

SNODGRASS
Here's the address. Report for work
first thing in the morning.

The woman leaves. SNODGRASS looks down at his appointment sheet.

SNODGRASS (CONT'D)
Who's next?

LUCY
(jumping up)
We are! We are!

ETHEL
(jumping up with her)
We're together.

INT. EMPLOYMENT AGENCY - SNODGRASS'S DESK - CONTINUOUS

SNODGRASS - fiftyish, wire-rimmed glasses, white shirt with the sleeves rolled, a striped tie pulled loose. A patient man. Not infinitely patient. On the desk, a blotter, a pen set, and a metal box of index cards.

Lucy and Ethel settle into the two chairs facing the desk. Lucy crosses her ankles. Ethel puts her handbag on her knees like a shield.

SNODGRASS
I see. Well, what job did you have in mind?

LUCY
Uh, what kind of jobs do you have open?

SNODGRASS
Well, what do you do?

LUCY
What kind of jobs do you have open?

SNODGRASS
Well, what do you do?

LUCY
What kind of jobs do you have open?

Snodgrass looks from Lucy to Ethel and back.

SNODGRASS
You go first this time.

LUCY
All right.

SNODGRASS
What do you do?

LUCY
What kind of jobs do you have open?

SNODGRASS
No! Cut that out! Please tell me,
what do you do? Are you
stenographers?

Lucy grabs it.

LUCY
Oh, yes, that's it. We're
stenographers.

SNODGRASS
Well, why didn't you say so? I have
a lot of stenographic jobs
available.

LUCY
Oh, good.

SNODGRASS
How fast can you type?

Lucy holds her hands up and wiggles her fingers in the air –
a pantomime of typing.

LUCY
Oh, about this fast.

Snodgrass watches the fingers. Looks down at his notepad.

SNODGRASS
Oh, I see. And how about your
typing?

Under the desk, Lucy nudges Ethel's foot.

ETHEL
Uh, mine's not as good as hers.

SNODGRASS
No.

Snodgrass sets his pen down.

SNODGRASS (CONT'D)
Look, ladies, let's be honest with
one another. I can't find you a job
until you can tell me what you can
really do. Now – what do you do?

LUCY

What kind of jobs do you have open?

Snodgrass closes his eyes. Opens them.

SNODGRASS

All right. Let's try it another way. I have a list. I will read off the jobs that I have available, and you tell me if you've had any experience in that line.

LUCY

Oh, fine.

He opens the metal box and pulls out a stack of index cards. Reads the first one.

SNODGRASS

Bookkeeper.

Lucy and Ethel shake their heads.

SNODGRASS (CONT'D)

Comptometer operator.

They shake their heads.

SNODGRASS (CONT'D)

Dental technician.

They shake their heads.

SNODGRASS (CONT'D)

Insurance adjuster.

They shake their heads. The hope is leaving their faces.

SNODGRASS (CONT'D)

Registered nurse.

They shake their heads. Slower this time. Ethel glances at Lucy.

SNODGRASS (CONT'D)

P.B.X. operator.

They shake their heads and look at each other. A little wild-eyed.

SNODGRASS (CONT'D)

Well, I've only got one left. Candy-makers. Have you ever had any experience making candy?

Lucy does not hesitate.

LUCY

What luck – you just hit our specialty! I don't know why we didn't tell you before.

SNODGRASS

You're candy-makers?

ETHEL

Oh, yes. We've made a lot of candy.

Snodgrass looks at them. He decides not to investigate.

SNODGRASS

You can begin work today at Kramer's Kandy Kitchen.

LUCY

Oh, thank you.

ETHEL

Thank you.

Lucy and Ethel stand. Handshakes. Smiles. They walk out of the office with the bearing of two women who have just solved a problem that has not yet begun.

CUT TO:

EXT. EMPLOYMENT AGENCY – MORNING

Lucy and Ethel on the sidewalk. Bright sun. Lucy adjusts her gloves. Ethel holds the address slip.

ETHEL

Candy-makers?

LUCY

How hard can it be?

They walk. Heels clicking. Headed east.

CUT TO:

INT. RICARDO APARTMENT – LIVING ROOM – DAY

The ironing board is set up where the coffee table usually goes. A basket of wrinkled laundry sits on the sofa, a can of spray starch on the side table next to the candy dish.

RICKY stands at the ironing board in an undershirt and slacks, a dish towel thrown over one shoulder. He is pressing a blouse with the intense focus of a man defusing a bomb. A thin curl of smoke rises from the fabric.

He does not notice the smoke. A KNOCK at the door. He sets the iron down and opens it.

FRED stands in the hallway in a moth-eaten undershirt and old trousers held up by suspenders, a kerchief knotted over his head. He looks like he has been in a fight he did not start.

RICKY
(whistling)
Oh, hiya, Fred.

FRED
Hi, Rick.

RICKY
Well, don't you look cute. What are you doing with that scarf on top of your head?

FRED
Oh! Oh, you mean this. I was cleaning the apartment and I didn't want to get any dust in my hair.

Ricky nods. Reasonable.

RICKY
Hey, take a tip from me – from an old housewife like me, will ya – and don't let that iron get too hot. You might scorch something.

FRED
Really?

RICKY
Yeah.

Fred glances at the ironing board. At the blouse. At the brown mark spreading across the collar.

FRED
You mean, uh – like this?

Ricky looks down. Lifts the iron. The scorch is unmistakable.

RICKY
That's the, uh – that's the general idea, yes.

RICKY (CONT'D)
Well, I thought I'd tell Lucy that
this was, uh, an original new
design.

FRED
That story won't work.

RICKY
No, eh? Why not?

FRED
Ethel has three blouses with that
same design.

They look at the scorch mark. Two men, same problem, same
failed solution.

FRED (CONT'D)
Listen, you know what's really
tough? Silk stockings.

RICKY
Yeah, how about that?

FRED
They're really tough to iron.

RICKY
You're not supposed to iron silk
stockings.

FRED
No?

RICKY
No. Fred, anybody knows that.

FRED
Look, just make sure that you use
plenty of starch when you wash
them.

RICKY
Oh. I see. I'll show you. I got a
couple of them over here.

Ricky picks up a pair of stockings from the laundry basket.
Holds them up. They are rigid — starched stiff, pressed with
creases sharp enough to cut paper. They do not drape. They
stand.

RICKY (CONT'D)
Here. See?

FRED
Oh, beautiful.

RICKY
Now, you seen better creases than
that anyplace?

FRED
My boy, you're a regular Margaret
McBride.

RICKY
Why, sure, man, sure.

They admire the stockings. Two men who have no idea what
they're looking at.

RICKY (CONT'D)
Oh, you know something? I been
thinking about that dinner, you
know?

FRED
Yeah?

RICKY
Yeah. I think it's silly for both
of us to cook a whole meal, you
know? So I thought what we should
do is pool our talents - I'll cook
the main course and you cook the
dessert.

FRED
Okay.

RICKY
Now let's see. How about arroz con
pollo?

FRED
Well, which is that - the main
course or the dessert?

RICKY
Chicken and rice.

FRED
Oh-ho! I seen my mother do it a
hundred times.

RICKY
I love it.

RICKY (CONT'D)
Well listen, I tell you what. Can
you bake a cake for dessert?

FRED
Will I - a big juicy one, seven
layers thick.

RICKY
Yeah? With frosting?

FRED
Globs of frosting.

Both men chuckle.

RICKY
Boy, this is going to be the best
meal our wives ever had.

They stand in the living room - scorched blouse on the
ironing board, rigid stockings in hand, the dinner plan
settled. Complete confidence. Zero ability.

END OF ACT ONE

ACT TWO

CUT TO:

EXT. KRAMER'S KANDY KITCHEN - DAY

A squat brick building on a commercial block. A painted sign
over the entrance: KRAMER'S KANDY KITCHEN. Women in white
smocks file through the front door. Lucy and Ethel approach
from the sidewalk, address slip in hand.

CUT TO:

INT. KRAMER'S KANDY KITCHEN - DIPPING ROOM - DAY

A long marble slab runs the length of the room - at one
station, a big puddle of melted chocolate with cream centers
in neat rows; beside it, an empty station with its own
puddle, untouched, waiting. The air is thick and sweet.

A SKILLED WORKER sits at the first station - middle-aged,
quick hands, white smock. She picks up a cream center, rolls
it deftly in the chocolate, coats it evenly, sets it on the
other side, and with the excess on her fingers makes a small
decorative swirl on top. She does this the way a pianist
plays scales. Without thinking.

LUCY and ETHEL – in smock-type aprons and candy kitchen caps – walk in behind the FORELADY, a tall, broad-shouldered woman in a starched white supervisor's coat, her hair pinned under a hairnet, a clipboard against her ribs like a weapon. She does not smile. It is possible she has never smiled.

FORELADY

All right, girls. This is the first stop. Now you understand from your indoctrination session – you're here for one purpose. To work.

LUCY

Yes, ma'am.

FORELADY

Ricardo, I'm going to put you to work chocolate dipping. You say you've had experience.

LUCY

Oh, yes, ma'am. I'm a dipper from way back. They used to call me the big dipper.

The Forelady does not blink.

FORELADY

There's no room in this plant for levity, however weak.

LUCY

(smile vanishing)

Yes, ma'am.

FORELADY

All right, Ricardo. That's your place.

She points to the empty station beside the skilled worker. Lucy sits. The marble slab stretches in front of her – the chocolate puddle, the cream centers, the same setup as the woman beside her.

FORELADY (CONT'D)

Mertz, I'm going to put you to work down in the chocolate boxing department. Follow me.

ETHEL

Yes, ma'am.

Ethel follows the Forelady out, glancing back. Lucy gives a small wave with chocolate-free fingers. It is the last time her fingers will be chocolate-free today.

Lucy watches the woman beside her. Pick up, roll, coat, set, swirl. Pick up, roll, coat, set, swirl. It looks easy.

LUCY
(to herself)
Hey, this is fun.

She reaches for a cream center. Gets it on the second try – the first try it shoots out of her fingers like a wet seed. She dips it in the chocolate. Rolls it. The coating is thick on one side, bare on the other. She dips again. Now it is the size of a golf ball.

She sets it on the slab and attempts the decorative swirl on top. The result does not resemble a swirl. It resembles a fingerprint at a crime scene.

She glances at the skilled worker's row of finished chocolates: uniform, glossy, each one topped with an identical flourish. She looks at her own: three lumps of varying size, none of them symmetrical.

She tries another. Worse.

Her nose itches. Both hands are covered in chocolate to the wrist.

LUCY (CONT'D)
(to the skilled worker)
What do you do when your nose
itches?

The woman does not look up. Lucy rubs her nose with her wrist. A brown streak across her cheek.

A FLY buzzes into the room. It circles Lucy's station, drawn by the chocolate. Lucy swats at it with a coated hand. Misses. Swats again. The fly lands on a cream center. Lucy lunges.

LUCY (CONT'D)
There's a fly in here.

The skilled worker keeps working. The fly keeps circling. Lucy's chocolates keep getting worse. Chocolate is on her apron, her cap, one ear. The slab around her station is a small chocolate accident.

The FORELADY returns. She walks to Lucy's station and stops. Looks at the slab. Looks at the row of chocolates Lucy has produced. Picks one up. It is the size of a small fist.

She sets it down. Looks at the skilled worker's output. Looks at Lucy's output. Back to Lucy.

She does not say a word. She does not need to.

FORELADY
Come with me, Ricardo.

Lucy stands. Wipes her hands on her apron, which makes the apron worse without making her hands better. She follows the Forelady out of the dipping room.

Behind her, the skilled worker picks up another cream center. Roll, coat, set, swirl. She has not looked up once.

CUT TO:

INT. RICARDO APARTMENT - KITCHEN - LATE AFTERNOON

The kitchen. Later. Ricky at the stove in his undershirt, two pots going. The counter is less organized than it was this morning. A bag of rice sits open beside the stove.

CUT TO:

INT. RICARDO APARTMENT - LIVING ROOM - LATE AFTERNOON

The apartment has slipped. Laundry basket still on the sofa, dust rag on the radio console, the ironing board leaning against the wall at a bad angle - slowly sliding.

RICKY is in the kitchen doorway when FRED arrives through the front door carrying a broom with the sports section of the newspaper clipped to the handle at eye level.

RICKY
Hiya, Fred!

FRED
Hi, Rick. How do you like my new invention?

RICKY
What is it?

FRED
Well, I can sweep the rug and read the sport pages at the same time.

RICKY
Pretty clever.

FRED
Why, sure. You know, the only reason that women claim that housework is so hard is because they don't use their heads.

RICKY
I guess so.

Ricky notices what Fred is carrying in his other hand – a cake plate covered with a dish towel.

RICKY (CONT'D)
What you got there?

FRED
Oh, I brought my cake.

RICKY
Oh.

FRED
(setting it down, removing the towel)
Seven layers of luscious devil's food. Wait till you see it.

He lifts the towel. The cake is flat. Dense. A dark disc roughly one inch tall. It does not look like seven layers of anything.

RICKY
What happened to the other six layers?

FRED
Well, they're all in there. Some of them just didn't rise very much.

RICKY
Well, you can put on a lot of frosting.

FRED
What do you mean, "put on"? The frosting's already in it.

RICKY
In it?

FRED

Yeah. I mixed it all up together
before I baked the cake.

Ricky looks at the cake. Looks at Fred.

RICKY

Well, maybe you'd better wait until
breakfast and serve it as a
pancake.

FRED

Oh, never mind, now. How about your
part of the meal?

RICKY

Well, it's coming along fine.

FRED

Good.

INT. RICARDO APARTMENT - KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

They move into the kitchen. Two pots on the stove - a
pressure cooker on the back burner, hissing faintly, a large
pot on the front with the lid on. Flour on the counter.
Eggshells in the sink.

RICKY

Yeah. I got the rice cooking.

RICKY (CONT'D)

Hey, listen, by the way - what do
you know about rice?

FRED

Well, I had it thrown at me on one
of the darkest days of my life.

RICKY

No, never mind that. I mean how
much do you think we should use for
four people?

FRED

Well, I don't know. People like
that stuff.

RICKY

Well, how does one pound per person
sound?

FRED
That sounds about right.

RICKY
That's good, because that's what I
put in – four pounds.

FRED
Good. That's good.

The large pot on the front burner. Four pounds of rice and
water, lid on, heat up. Neither man looks at it.

RICKY
Well, let me see. I got the, uh – I
got chickens cooking in the
pressure cooker.

FRED
Yeah.

RICKY
Now, how long do you think they
should take?

FRED
Oh, I don't know. I'd say about an
hour and a half.

The pressure cooker hisses. A little louder than before.
Neither man notices.

The pressure cooker EXPLODES.

A bang like a gunshot. The lid launches. Steam fills the
kitchen. Ricky and Fred duck, grab each other, scramble
backward into the counter.

RICKY
What was that?! What was that?!

FRED
Hey, Rick, what was that noise?!

The steam clears. Ricky moves toward the stove. The pressure
cooker is open and empty.

RICKY
(looking inside)
Hey, what happened to my chickens?!
I had two chickens in there!

FRED
Well, they got to be here
someplace. Chick, chick. Chick,
chick, chick.

Fred looks around the kitchen. Under the table. Behind the door.

FRED (CONT'D)
Hey – what happened? Are those your
birds up there?

They both look up. Two chickens are stuck to the kitchen ceiling.

RICKY
Yeah.

FRED
Now what are we going to do?

RICKY
Well, let's wash them off. Come on.

They peel the chickens off the ceiling. Carry them to the sink. Turn the water on.

FRED
All right. Turn the water on.
Here's the brush.

RICKY
Give me some of this stuff here.

FRED
Give me some more of that stuff
over here.

They are scrubbing chickens in the sink with dish soap and a brush. Two men in undershirts, washing poultry like it is a reasonable thing to do.

RICKY
Attaboy. This one's really strong.

Behind them, on the stove, the lid on the rice pot begins to rise.

FRED
(turning, seeing it)
Hey, Ricky – what's this?!

Rice is pushing up under the lid. A white tide rising. Ricky turns from the sink. His face.

RICKY

Oh, no!

The lid slides off. Rice pours over the rim of the pot – a slow, thick, unstoppable cascade onto the stovetop.

RICKY (CONT'D)

Catch the rice! Hurry up, Fred!

They drop the chickens in the sink and lunge for the stove. Fred grabs a bowl. Ricky grabs a pot. The rice is faster than both of them.

RICKY (CONT'D)

Hurry up, will you?! It's still coming!

Rice spills off the stovetop onto the counter. Off the counter onto the floor. It does not stop. Four pounds of dry rice, fully hydrated, expanding into something that wants the whole kitchen.

FRED

I'm going!

RICKY

Get it! Get it! Get it! It's like a volcano!

They are scooping rice into bowls, pots, anything with edges. It keeps coming. For every scoop they remove, another wave rolls over the rim. Rice on the floor. Rice on their shoes. Rice in the sink with the chickens.

RICKY (CONT'D)

Get going!

FRED

I'm going!

RICKY

Fred, here!

The kitchen. Rice on every surface. Chicken debris on the ceiling. The cake – one inch of compressed devil's food – sitting untouched on the counter, the only thing in the room that has not moved.

Ricky and Fred stand in the middle of it. Covered in rice. Out of breath. Out of ideas.

Nothing left to say.

CUT TO:

INT. KRAMER'S KANDY KITCHEN - WRAPPING DEPARTMENT - DAY

A long room. A conveyor belt runs from a production opening on one wall, through the room, and disappears through an opening in the opposite wall into the packing department beyond. The belt is still. Wrapping papers and empty boxes are stationed at two positions along its length.

The belt is waiting.

The FORELADY walks LUCY to one of the stations. Lucy's apron has chocolate on it from the dipping room. Her cap is slightly crooked.

FORELADY

All right, girls. Listen carefully.
This is the wrapping department.

LUCY

Yes, ma'am.

FORELADY

Now, the candy will pass by on this conveyor belt and continue into the next room where the girls will pack it. Your job is to take each piece of candy and wrap it in one of these papers, and then put it back on the belt. You understand?

LUCY

Yes, sir.

The Forelady stares at her.

LUCY (CONT'D)

Yes, ma'am.

FORELADY

(calling toward the
production room)

Let her roll!

Nothing happens.

FORELADY (CONT'D)

Let her roll!

Still nothing.

FORELADY (CONT'D)

Well! Wait here. Somebody's asleep
at the switch.

She disappears through the production opening. Lucy is alone at the belt.

A door opens behind her. ETHEL walks in — apron rumpled, cap askew, looking like she has been through something.

LUCY

Whew! What are you doing up here? I thought you were downstairs boxing chocolates.

ETHEL

Oh, they kicked me out of there fast.

LUCY

Why?

ETHEL

I kept pinching them to see what kind they were.

ETHEL (CONT'D)

This is the fourth department I've been in.

LUCY

Oh? I didn't do so well either.

The Forelady returns.

FORELADY

All right, girls. Now, this is your last chance. If one piece of candy gets past you and into the packing room unwrapped, you're fired.

LUCY

Yes, ma'am.

FORELADY

(calling out)

Let her roll!

The belt shudders. Starts. Chocolates appear through the production opening, riding single file, evenly spaced. Slow. The Forelady watches for a moment, then exits. The door closes. Lucy and Ethel are alone.

Lucy picks up the first chocolate. Wraps it in a small square of paper. Sets it back on the belt. Ethel does the same. Pick up, wrap, set down. Pick up, wrap, set down.

LUCY
Well, this is easier.

ETHEL
Yeah.

LUCY
We can handle this okay.

They settle into a rhythm. For a stretch, it works. They exchange a look. Maybe this will be fine.

A VOICE from the production room, muffled through the wall:
"Speed it up!"

The belt jumps. The spacing between chocolates tightens. The easy rhythm breaks.

Lucy's hands move faster. Ethel's move faster. Their wrapping gets sloppy — paper folded unevenly, corners sticking up. One chocolate sails past Lucy before she can grab it. She lunges and catches it just before it reaches the wall opening.

Ethel grabs Lucy's arm.

LUCY (CONT'D)
Listen, Ethel, I think we're
fighting a losing game.

Two more chocolates queue up behind the one she is wrapping. Then three. The belt does not care.

The belt is now moving faster than their hands. Chocolates pile up at their stations, threatening to stream past into the packing room.

Lucy looks at the chocolates accumulating in front of her. Looks at the wall opening where unwrapped candy must not go. Looks at the chocolates. Makes a decision.

She grabs a handful and stuffs them into her mouth.

Her cheeks expand. She chews frantically, trying to make room, but the belt keeps delivering. She shoves in two more. Her jaw works. Her eyes widen. Her cheeks are packed solid.

Ethel sees what Lucy is doing. Ethel starts eating. Both women chewing as fast as they can, chocolates in both hands, the belt still coming.

Lucy's mouth is full. She cannot fit another piece. Her hands find her candy kitchen cap. She lifts it, tucks chocolates against her head, presses the cap back down. It bulges. She pushes it flatter.

Ethel does the same. Both caps are misshapen now – lumpy and uneven, pressed down hard over hidden cargo.

Still the belt comes. Lucy starts stuffing chocolates down the front of her smock. Into her apron pockets. Into every fold and crevice of the uniform. Ethel follows. They are, piece by piece, becoming human storage.

But the belt behind them is clear. Every chocolate that reaches the wall opening is wrapped. Not a single piece has made it through into the packing room.

A door opens. The Forelady walks in.

She moves along the belt, inspecting. The conveyor is immaculate. Every chocolate accounted for. She looks at the wall opening into the packing room. Clean.

Lucy and Ethel stand at their stations. Smiling. Cheeks packed. Hats deformed. Uniforms stuffed to capacity. They nod pleasantly.

The Forelady does not notice. From where she stands, two workers are doing excellent work. She is pleased.

FORELADY

Fine. You're doing splendidly.

She leans back toward the production room opening and calls out:

FORELADY (CONT'D)

Speed it up a little!

Lucy's face. Cheeks bulging. Cap lumpy. Chocolate on her chin.

Ethel's face. Same.

They look at each other. There is nothing left – no room in their mouths, no room in their hats, no room in their uniforms. And the belt is about to go faster.

Nobody moves.

CUT TO:

EXT. RICARDO APARTMENT BUILDING - EVENING

The brownstone. Dusk. The fourth-floor windows lit amber. The city settling into night.

CUT TO:

INT. RICARDO APARTMENT - LIVING ROOM - EVENING

The apartment as we left it - laundry basket on the sofa, dust rag on the radio, the ironing board leaning against the wall. The kitchen door is closed. The living room is quiet.

The front door opens. LUCY and ETHEL enter. They are still in their day clothes - Lucy's olive dress wrinkled, her pearls askew, a smear of chocolate on her jaw she has not noticed. Ethel's hat is crooked. They move like women who have been on their feet for eight hours doing something they should never have attempted.

LUCY

Ricky?

No answer.

ETHEL

Fred?

Nothing.

LUCY

Ricky?

ETHEL

I wonder where they are.

Ethel puts a hand on her stomach.

ETHEL (CONT'D)

Lucy, have you got any bicarbonate of soda?

LUCY

Yeah. I got some in the kitchen.

ETHEL

I'll get it.

Ethel heads for the kitchen door. Stops. There is a note taped to it.

ETHEL (CONT'D)

(reading)

"Dear girls, please do not go in the kitchen until we can explain. We'll be back in a few minutes."

LUCY

Gee, I wonder what's in there.

ETHEL
I hate to think.

LUCY
You stay here.

ETHEL
Why you?

LUCY
I'm stronger than you are.

Lucy walks to the kitchen door. Puts her hand on the knob.
Pushes it open. Looks inside.

She SCREAMS.

LUCY (CONT'D)
Oh, Ethel!

ETHEL
(rushing over)
What is it?

LUCY
Ethel, it's a shambles! Food all
over the place – on the floor, on
the walls, on the ceiling – it's a
mess.

Ethel peeks past Lucy into the kitchen. She does not go in.

ETHEL
I don't want to clean it up.

LUCY
Oh, no. I can't.

Lucy closes the kitchen door. They stand in the living room,
too tired to move, staring at the closed door as though it
might open on its own.

The front door opens. RICKY and FRED enter. They are rumpled
– Ricky's undershirt has a rice stain down the front, Fred's
suspenders are hanging off one shoulder. They are carrying
two large gift boxes.

RICKY
Lucy, oh! Oh, Lucy, thank goodness
you're home. Something awful
happened.

LUCY
No.

RICKY

Yeah. Don't go in the kitchen until
Fred and I —

LUCY

I've already been in there.

Ricky stops. His prepared explanation dies on the spot.

RICKY

Oh. Oh, well. Don't worry about it.
We'll clean it up.

LUCY

Thank you.

A beat. All four of them in the living room. The same room
where the bet was made. The same sofa, the same armchair, the
same lamp light. Nobody is arguing. Nobody is posturing.

RICKY

Listen, we don't know how you girls
feel about it, but we'd like to
forget the whole thing. We're lousy
housewives.

FRED

Hideous.

LUCY

Well, we're not so good at bringing
home the bacon either.

ETHEL

We got fired off our first job.

LUCY

Yeah.

Four lines. Both sides done. The bet is over without a
winner.

RICKY

Well, look — what say we go back to
the way we were? We'll make the
money, and you spend it.

LUCY

Oh, that's great with me.

ETHEL

Good idea, Fred.

RICKY
And listen, girls – we never
realized how tough it was to run a
house before.

Lucy and Ethel soften.

RICKY (CONT'D)
So just to show you our
appreciation, we brought you a
little present.

LUCY
Really?

ETHEL
You did?

Ricky and Fred hold up the gift boxes. Large. Wrapped with
ribbon. They present them with genuine pride.

RICKY
For each one of you – a five-pound
box of chocolates.

Lucy takes her box. Looks at it. Five pounds of chocolate.
She has spent the entire day wrapping chocolate, eating
chocolate, hiding chocolate in her mouth and her hat and her
clothes.

Ethel takes hers. Same face.

They smile. They say thank you. The smiles stay fixed and do
not reach their eyes.

A single chocolate drops from inside Lucy's sleeve and rolls
across the floor. Nobody picks it up.

Ricky puts his arm around Lucy. Fred stands beside Ethel.
Four people in a living room, holding chocolate, the kitchen
door closed behind them, the day finally over.

Nobody won. Nobody says so.

FADE TO:

EXT. RICARDO APARTMENT BUILDING - NIGHT

The brownstone. The fourth-floor windows, warm and amber. The
same building, the same windows, the same city as the night
the bet was made. A taxi passes below. The El rumbles in the
distance.

The lights in the fourth-floor window go out, one by one.

FADE TO BLACK.

END OF EPISODE